

unlikely to generate headlines about how the sport is run in India.

On the field, however, his appointment meant an abrupt shift in philosophy midway through the qualifiers: from Marquez's possession-based style to Jamil's defensive structure.

The transition between two vastly different systems disrupted continuity. Across four matches, 38 players were called up and 18 changes were made to the starting elevens since the Bangladesh fixture in March.

What should have been the pinnacle of Jamil's coaching career instead became a trial by fire — a faltering qualifying campaign riddled with obstacles.

His job was made harder by the ISL's uncertain future, players arriving at his first camp in August without proper pre-season training, and with Mohun Bagan refusing to release its players despite the FIFA window. "We will adjust with the players we have," Jamil said at the time.

To his credit, India finished third in the eight-team CAFA Nations Cup, recording positive results against Tajikistan and Oman and pushing Iran close. Those outcomes briefly restored optimism ahead of the double-header against Singapore.

But the problems persisted. Before the Singapore games, 14 of the 23 players in the

travelling squad failed to report on the first day. Rahim Ali, Subhasish Bose, and Lalengmawia Ralte, who would later impress against Singapore, were not even part of his original probables.

Lalengmawia is easily India's best all-round midfielder — a player the team can be built around for the next few years. But why did the coach decide his experience and quality were vital only three days before the Singapore home tie?

Despite his reservations, Jamil delivered on the promise of attacking football for his first home match in charge. His team played with intent and energy, qualities that had been missing from the national side in recent years, but fatigue soon eroded that intensity.

Jamil attributed the errors to the lack of top-tier match practice. "Yes, before this preparation also, we tried to call players early, but we didn't get them since there were many

problems. We had to solve it," he said.

It's worth asking whether the result, despite India's attacking effort, will only harden Jamil's belief that

defence-first football is the way forward.

"At home, we have to attack," he said when asked if India would persist with that approach, before adding, "I like defending more. You can say, today, we attacked and lost. For me, the result matters."

Still, Jamil should not be made a scapegoat for the malaise surrounding the team. Everyone knew what they were getting with him, yet somehow expected something different. In 15 matches before his appointment, India had scored more than one goal only once — a 3-0 win over the Maldives — and failed to score in 10.

The CAFA Nations Cup and the home fixture against Singapore suggested Jamil deserves time and space to rebuild. If India is to become a disciplined, low-block side capable of grinding out results, he needs institutional backing.

Jamil's defensive philosophy may not please the purists, but results are now a necessity. His club-level success often relied on foreign strikers who could spearhead his counter-attacks. With the national team, even Sunil Chhetri can't answer the lingering question: who after Chhetri? Jamil defended his inclusion, saying, "He is one of the best strikers we have."

Yet with two dead rubbers left in the campaign, Jamil was non-committal about the veteran's future. "We will think about it later. This is not the right time to speak on Chhetri," he said.

With the next World Cup and Asian Cup qualifiers likely two years away, a decision on the 40-year-old's international future should be among Jamil's easiest calls.

But for Jamil to put the pieces together, he needs help from those above him. There is still no clarity on the ISL and I-League's status, and three international windows could pass before the domestic structure resumes.

If decisive action doesn't follow soon, this failed qualification campaign will no longer be an exception — it will become the norm.



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